

# 3

# Merchants and Capital

> ‘As long as there remain opportunities for business among his own countrymen, there the Indian merchant will be found.’
>
> —Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi[1]

M.K. Gandhi, born into a traditional Gujarati business community, experienced the Great Indian Migration Wave at close quarters during his long stay in South Africa. He saw that the Wave affected not only labour but also the capital and business enterprises that moved with it. These enterprises were closely linked with particular business communities whose migration trajectories started much earlier and whose destinations at times differed from those seen in the Great Indian Migration Wave. These communities were often perceived as villains, similar to how Shakespeare portrayed Shylock, a Jewish moneylender, in *The Merchant of Venice*. Nevertheless, in 2014, over 60 per cent of India’s hundred most rich business leaders belonged to these communities that formed less than 5 per cent of the country’s population.[2] Understanding the history of migration of these communities is critical in explaining their dominance in the world of Indian business. Who comprised these communities, where did they go and what did they do? To answer this, we must enter the fascinating world of the *Parsi*s, *Chettiar*s, Punjabis, Sindhis, Marwaris and Gujaratis, among